

SOLVED PRACTICE WORKBOOK

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing

01 Post-Gupta chronology and evidence spine

Original deterministic study schematic

Core source ladder

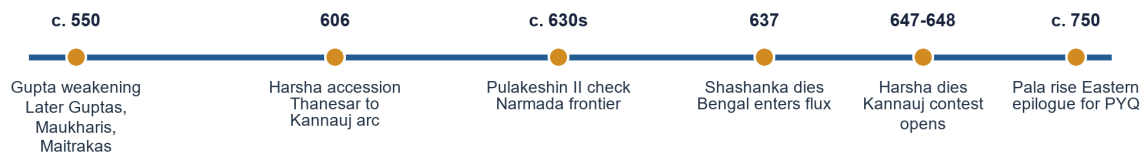
Repository topic owners -> OCR Sharma and Upinder -> no forced current-affairs insertion.
Use Bana, Xuanzang, Banskhara-Madhuban and Aihole together; each has genre bias.

UPSC-safe frame

Not simple collapse. This is a bridge from Gupta imperial concentration to regional early medieval state formation.
Harsha matters, but eastern India and post-Shashanka change matter equally.

Memory test

Kannauj, Xuanzang, Aihole, Gauda, Kamarupa, land grants, Nalanda, regionalisation.



Timeline is schematic. Direct dates are secure where shown; wider territorial claims remain evidence-bound.

Original deterministic study visual; labels are explanatory, not textual quotations.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

Solved topic-specific MCQs

Verified PYQ 1 - GS-I Mains 2020 Q2 (exact wording locally preserved)

Pala period is the most significant phase in the history of Buddhism in India. Enumerate. (150 words)

Status: Exact wording preserved locally through the repository's verified package for Topic 10 and the 2018-2023 Mains routing ledger. This topic owns the eastern-transition bridge needed to answer it.

Model answer: [CLAIM] The Pala centuries were the highest late-Indian institutional phase of Buddhism, though the superlative "most significant" must be qualified against earlier Ashokan and early-sangha milestones. [EVIDENCE AND ANALYSIS] 1. The Pala world sustained the great mahavihara network of Nalanda, Vikramashila, Odantapuri and Somapura, proving concentration of scholastic institutions in eastern India. 2. Mahayana and Vajrayana thought flourished in these centres, showing doctrinal vitality rather than mere survival. 3. Teachers such as Atisha Dipankara illustrate trans-Himalayan circulation of persons and texts. 4. Pala bronze, stone and palm-leaf manuscript traditions influenced Nepal and Tibet, proving artistic and ritual transmission beyond India. 5. Royal and landed support tied Buddhism to the agrarian-political consolidation of the east after earlier post-Harsha turbulence. [LIMIT] The claim should not erase the foundational significance of early Buddhism, Ashoka or non-royal Buddhist communities. [VERDICT] The Pala phase was therefore the decisive late-classical peak of Indian Buddhism, especially in institutional, scholastic and trans-regional terms. **Why this earns marks:** It answers the directive directly, gives five named evidence units, ties them to what they prove, adds a qualification and closes with a graded verdict.

Routed PYQ 2 - Prelims GS-I 2020 Q24 (audited demand; original paper and key not held locally)

Locally audited demand: chronological order involving the Pratihara, Pallava, Chola and Pala dynasties.

Status: Audited routed demand from the 2018-2023 Prelims ledger. Official key unavailable locally.

Answer / route: INFERRED ORDER FROM STANDARD CHRONOLOGY: Pallava -> Gurjara-Pratihara -> Pala -> Imperial Chola.

- Pallavas are securely earlier, with their major political arc beginning centuries before the Palas and imperial Cholas.
- Gurjara-Pratiharas emerge in the 8th century, slightly before or at the very beginning of the Pala line.
- Palas begin in the mid-8th century with Gopala.
- Imperial Cholas belong mainly from the 9th century onward.

Why this earns marks: It states the best-supported chronological route while clearly marking that the official 2020 key is not held locally.

Routed PYQ 3 - Prelims GS-I 2020 Q97 (audited demand; exact options not held locally)

Locally audited demand: historical places Bhilsa, Dwarasamudra, Girinagar and Sthanesvara in state-dynasty matching.

Status: Routed demand only. Official key unavailable locally; exact option wording not held in the repository.

Answer / route: Use elimination through fixed pairs rather than claim an unheld option letter.

- Dwarasamudra = Hoysala centre (later medieval, not Topic 22's Harsha world).
- Sthanesvara = Thanesar, the Pushyabhuti-Harsha base.
- Girinagar = Junagadh/Girnar-Saurashtra zone in western India.
- Bhilsa = Vidisha/Malwa region in central India.

The likely official option would depend on how the paper paired these places with states or dynasties; since that sheet is not locally present, this workbook honestly stops at the concept route.

Why this earns marks: It gives all secure pairings while refusing to invent a missing option letter.

Routed PYQ 4 - Prelims GS-I 2021 Q34 (audited demand; original paper and key not held locally)

Locally audited demand: kingdoms of northern India after Gupta decline.

Status: Routed demand from the 2018-2023 Prelims ledger. Official key unavailable locally.

Answer / route: The safe north-Indian post-Gupta cluster includes Later Guptas, Maukharis, Pushyabhutis, Maitrakas and Gauda under Shashanka. If the question mixes northern and southern houses, eliminate Pallavas, Cholas or deeper Deccan lines unless the option specifically asks for a contrast.

This is a concept-solving route, not an official-key claim.

Why this earns marks: It converts a missing paper into a high-quality elimination framework instead of pretending access to an unavailable official key.

Workbook MCQ 01

Which line belongs squarely to the immediate post-Gupta north Indian field?

- A. Later Guptas
- B. Satavahanas
- C. Ikshvakus
- D. Kushanas

Answer: A. Later Guptas are part of the directly relevant north Indian matrix after the imperial Gupta phase.

Workbook MCQ 02

The Maukharis are most closely tied in Topic 22 to:

- A. Badami
- B. Kannauj
- C. Amaravati
- D. Korkai

Answer: B. Kannauj is the key Maukhari centre that later becomes central to Harsha's order.

Workbook MCQ 03

Rajyashri's husband was:

- A. Bhaskaravarman
- B. Pulakeshin II
- C. Grahavarman
- D. Gopala

Answer: C. Grahavarman, the Maukhari ruler, is the crucial marriage link in the accession crisis.

Workbook MCQ 04

The most accurate statement about Harsha's capital shift is:

- A. He never moved beyond Thanesar.
- B. He ruled permanently from Pataliputra.
- C. He made Valabhi his capital.
- D. He moved the effective centre from Thanesar to Kannauj at some stage of his reign.

Answer: D. Kannauj becomes the signature centre of Harsha's mature political order.

Workbook MCQ 05

The Narmada in Topic 22 is primarily remembered as:

- A. the line where Pulakeshin II checked Harsha
- B. Harsha's southernmost province
- C. the core river of Kamarupa
- D. the location of Nalanda

Answer: A. It marks the remembered frontier of Harsha's southern limit.

Workbook MCQ 06

Which source pairing reconstructs Harsha's world most directly?

- A. Ashokan edicts and *Periplus*
- B. *Harshacharita* and Xuanzang
- C. Sangam poems and *Arthashastra*
- D. *Rajatarangini* and *Ain-i-Akbari*

Answer: B. These are the two classic narrative anchors, supplemented by inscriptions.

Workbook MCQ 07

Banskhera and Madhuban inscriptions are most useful for studying:

- A. Chola naval expeditions
- B. Satavahana cave donations
- C. offices, dues and grant procedure under Harsha
- D. Harappan drainage

Answer: C. They are the documentary core for Harsha's state structure.

Workbook MCQ 08

What is the safest reading of Harsha's huge army figures in Sharma?

- A. Exact standing-strength census
- B. Pure fiction with no historical value
- C. Proof that Harsha ruled the whole south
- D. Likely inclusion of feudatory contingents and rhetorical inflation

Answer: D. The numbers are best treated critically, not literally.

Workbook MCQ 09

Shashanka was ruler of:

- A. Gauda
- B. Kamarupa
- C. Valabhi
- D. Malava only

Answer: A. Gauda under Shashanka is one of the core eastern markers of the period.

Workbook MCQ 10

Kamarupa corresponds most closely to:

- A. lower Godavari delta
- B. the Brahmaputra basin and adjoining Assam region
- C. central Rajasthan
- D. Saurashtra coast

Answer: B. It is the major north-eastern polity of the age.

Workbook MCQ 11

Which polity in Topic 22 provides the major western comparator to Harsha's north Indian core?

- A. Pandyas
- B. Cholas
- C. Maitrakas of Valabhi
- D. Kakatiyas

Answer: C. Valabhi matters as a western political node, not as Harsha's settled province.

Workbook MCQ 12

Which city becomes a wider sovereignty symbol after Harsha, especially in later north Indian struggles?

- A. Ujjain
- B. Pataliputra
- C. Kanchi
- D. Kannauj

Answer: D. Control over Kannauj becomes a hallmark of later early medieval power politics.

Workbook MCQ 13

The Pundravardhanabhukti land-sale records often describe endowed land as:

- A. fallow or uncultivated before settlement
- B. purely temple-owned from time immemorial
- C. sea-borne customs territory only
- D. military cantonment alone

Answer: A. That point is central to Sharma's agrarian-expansion reading.

Workbook MCQ 14

The mention of *dinaras* in Bengal charters mainly shows that:

- A. only cowries were used
- B. land could be purchased with gold coin in some eastern transactions
- C. the area was outside all fiscal administration
- D. all taxes had vanished

Answer: B. The plates show coin purchase and then tax-remitted religious endowment.

Workbook MCQ 15

Which statement best captures the role of grants in the east?

- A. They mattered only ritually.
- B. They were only anti-peasant instruments.
- C. They could aid cultivation and literacy while also strengthening intermediaries.
- D. They ended all community authority instantly.

Answer: C. The strongest answer is dual, not one-sided.

Workbook MCQ 16

The repeated mention of victory or military camps with horses, elephants and boats in Bengal suggests:

- A. a stateless forest society
- B. only literary imagination
- C. Mauryan continuity in identical form
- D. organised taxation, warfare and administration in regional states

Answer: D. This is one of Sharma's clearest signs of state formation in Bengal.

Workbook MCQ 17

Which ruler becomes especially important in the east after Shashanka's death?

- A. Bhaskaravarman
- B. Pushyamitra
- C. Kanishka
- D. Bimbisara

Answer: A. Bhaskaravarman's Kamarupa is central to the post-Shashanka eastern field.

Workbook MCQ 18

Why must Xuanzang be read with audience and purpose in mind?

- A. Because he wrote only about South India
- B. Because he wrote for a Tang imperial-monastic audience and could idealise or rely on hearsay
- C. Because he was Harsha's court poet
- D. Because he never studied Buddhism

Answer: B. Upinder makes this one of the key source-method lessons.

Workbook MCQ 19

The best generic label for *Harshacharita* is:

- A. neutral district gazetteer
- B. copper-plate charter
- C. courtly biography or akhyayika
- D. maritime trade manual

Answer: C. It is literary, political and historically valuable at the same time.

Workbook MCQ 20

Which statement on Harsha's religious profile is safest?

- A. He was only a Shaiva monarch with no Buddhist link.
- B. He was only a Buddhist king with no Shaiva link.
- C. He was secular in the modern constitutional sense.
- D. He appears Shaiva in inscriptions and Bana, but Buddhist-leaning in Xuanzang, with ecumenical public ritual.

Answer: D. That is the most evidence-balanced formulation.

Workbook MCQ 21

What is the safest statement on Nalanda in Topic 22?

- A. It developed over time but had major 7th-century prestige linked with Xuanzang.
- B. It belonged only to the Gupta topic and not to Harsha's age.
- C. It had no agrarian support base.
- D. It was already the same institution in every century from its origin onward.

Answer: A. Nalanda must be phased historically, not frozen into one static picture.

Workbook MCQ 22

Valabhi functions in Topic 22 primarily as:

- A. Harsha's Deccan capital
- B. a western polity and wider learning centre in the larger cultural-political field
- C. a Sangam port
- D. the site of Aihole inscription

Answer: B. Its value here is comparative and networked, not merely local.

Workbook MCQ 23

Which title or office appears in Harsha's administrative context?

- A. gopa
- B. adhyaksha of the Mauryan type only
- C. sarva-palli-pati
- D. amatyaputra of Megasthenes

Answer: C. Upinder explicitly notes the official called sarva-palli-pati.

Workbook MCQ 24

Which later development most clearly shows that Harsha's death did not produce a stable successor empire?

- A. Mauryan restoration
- B. Satavahana resurgence
- C. Hoysala expansion
- D. later struggle for Kannauj among major regional powers

Answer: D. The later contest for Kannauj proves the open-endedness of the post-Harsha field.

Workbook MCQ 25

Which claim about Rajyashri should be avoided?

- A. One elite crisis narrative proves the social status of all women in the age.
- B. Her marriage mattered politically.
- C. Her rescue matters in Bana's design of Harsha's rise.
- D. The episode is source-sensitive.

Answer: A. That is the classic overgeneralisation trap.

Workbook MCQ 26

Sharma's explanation of Kannauj's rise is best captured by which statement?

- A. It was a purely sacred city without military role.
- B. It fit a strategic doab-centred and more camp-oriented political order.
- C. It rose only because Roman trade shifted there.
- D. It replaced all eastern states completely.

Answer: B. Strategic location plus changing state structure is the key.

Workbook MCQ 27

Which source most directly checks Harsha's southward imperial image?

- A. Pundravardhanabhukti plates
- B. Banskhera inscription
- C. Aihole inscription
- D. *Nagananda*

Answer: C. Aihole is the rival prashasti that matters most for the Narmada frontier.

Workbook MCQ 28

Which tax sequence belongs to the Harsha-age inscriptional vocabulary discussed in this package?

- A. tulamana, dronavapa, kulyavapa
- B. shreni, nigama, nagara
- C. bhatta, vishti, setu
- D. bhaga, bhoga, kara, hiranya

Answer: D. This is the secure cluster noted in Upinder's summary.

Workbook MCQ 29

Early Pushyabhuti rulers are linked in inscriptional memory with the worship of:

- A. Surya
- B. only Skanda
- C. only Ganga
- D. only Krishna

Answer: A. Upinder explicitly notes early Pushyabhuti solar association.

Workbook MCQ 30

Why is eastern India especially significant in this topic?

- A. It adds a decorative regional appendix.
- B. It shows the integration of new agrarian-literate state societies into the mainstream historical record.
- C. It proves Harsha ruled Assam directly as a province.
- D. It eliminates the need to study land grants.

Answer: B. Eastern integration is one of the deepest historical processes in Topic 22.

Workbook MCQ 31

Which statement on urban decline is safest?

- A. Every town vanished after the Guptas.
- B. No change occurred in any urban centre.
- C. Some earlier centres lost weight, but regional states, coins, monasteries and strategic capitals show uneven transformation rather than total collapse.
- D. Urban history becomes irrelevant after 550 CE.

Answer: C. The best answer is nuanced and indicator-based.

Workbook MCQ 32

Which figure below is NOT a direct courtly or textual association of Harsha's age in this topic?

- A. Bana
- B. Mayura
- C. Matanga Divakara
- D. Kalidasa

Answer: D. Kalidasa belongs to the Gupta classical world, not Harsha's own courtly package.

Workbook MCQ 33

What immediately followed Prabhakaravardhana's death in Bana's sequence?

- A. Rajyavardhana's accession amid crisis
- B. Harsha's conquest of the Deccan
- C. Gopala's election in Bengal
- D. Xuanzang's return to China

Answer: A. The accession crisis begins before Harsha himself takes power.

Workbook MCQ 34

The phrase that best captures Harsha's rule is:

- A. total pan-Indian empire on the Mauryan model
- B. north Indian hegemon with layered allegiances and a bounded frontier
- C. purely symbolic kingship without territorial core
- D. only a monastery-state

Answer: B. That description holds direct rule, influence and limit together.

Workbook MCQ 35

Which reading of the Prayaga assembly is strongest?

- A. It was only a private devotional retreat.
- B. It was only a revenue audit.
- C. It fused royal charity, multi-sect display and the public ranking of subordinate powers.
- D. It had no political dimension.

Answer: C. This is the most UPSC-useful interpretation.

Workbook MCQ 36

Which process is clearly documented in eastern charters of this age?

- A. elimination of Sanskrit
- B. disappearance of districts
- C. abolition of all land rights
- D. grants, fiscal units, Sanskrit charters and settlement expansion

Answer: D. That is the core eastern process package.

Workbook MCQ 37

Which statement about Bhaskaravarman is the safest?

- A. He was a major 7th-century Kamarupa ruler whose rise shaped the eastern field after Shashanka.
- B. He was the author of *Harshacharita*.
- C. He was a Chalukya subordinate.
- D. He founded the Gupta era.

Answer: A. This is the securely useful level of formulation.

Workbook MCQ 38

Which historiographical pairing gives the best balanced answer to Topic 22?

- A. pure nationalist triumphalism and nothing else
- B. Sharma's structural model plus later regional-state corrections
- C. only colonial dismissal
- D. only a traveller's narrative

Answer: B. The package's final synthesis depends on this balance.

Workbook MCQ 39

Which question-type most strongly requires explicit source criticism?

- A. List Harsha's plays only.
- B. Name one eastern state only.
- C. Evaluate Xuanzang and Bana as sources for Harsha's age.
- D. Match one place with one river only.

Answer: C. This demand fails without discussion of genre, audience and bias.

Workbook MCQ 40

Pala Buddhism fits Topic 22 mainly because:

- A. it belongs to the Mauryan age
- B. it replaces all Gupta history
- C. it has no relation to eastern India
- D. the eastern transition after Shashanka eventually culminates in major Buddhist-political consolidation under the Palas

Answer: D. The workbook includes it as the east's longer arc, not because Topic 22 is secretly a Pala topic.

Remedial 01 - Harsha and all-India empire

Which correction is the most defensible?

- A. Harsha was a major north Indian hegemon, but the Deccan remained outside stable control and peripheral regions require graded language.
- B. Harsha ruled only one district around Thanesar.
- C. Harsha had no military role at all.
- D. Harsha's empire was identical to Ashoka's.

Answer: A. This correction is bounded, evidence-led and avoids both exaggeration and trivialisation. Why this earns marks: the correction restores direct core, peripheral influence and frontier limit in one sentence.

Remedial 02 - Bana as source

What is the correct correction to the statement "Banabhatta is a neutral historian"?

- A. Bana wrote only legal charters.
- B. Bana is a court poet and literary biographer whose work is indispensable but eulogistic and selective.
- C. Bana never wrote about Harsha.
- D. Bana is identical with Xuanzang.

Answer: B. That is the exact source-method posture required in this topic. Why this earns marks: it keeps the source usable while preventing naive literalism.

Remedial 03 - Meaning of land grants

Which correction best repairs the claim "Land grants were only religious charity"?

- A. They had no effect on society.
- B. They mattered only to monks.
- C. They also expanded cultivation, redistributed fiscal rights and strengthened local intermediaries.
- D. They abolished kingship.

Answer: C. Grants are political and agrarian technology, not only pious gesture. Why this earns marks: it gives both sides of the process and avoids ideological simplification.

Remedial 04 - Nalanda numbers

How should the famous Nalanda numbers be handled?

- A. Reject every traveller statement automatically.
- B. Use only archaeology and ignore texts.
- C. Accept 10,000 as exact because it sounds grand.
- D. Accept Nalanda's fame, but qualify the 10,000 figure through archaeology and Yijing's smaller number.

Answer: D. This is the most honest and historically mature answer. Why this earns marks: it preserves institutional significance while controlling numerical overclaim.

Remedial 05 - Dark age language

Which correction best repairs the phrase "Post-Gupta age was a dark age"?

- A. Better to describe it as regional reorganisation with uneven urban decline, agrarian expansion and new state formation.
- B. Better to call it timeless stagnation.
- C. Better to erase all conflict and change.
- D. Better to treat Harsha as a global emperor.

Answer: A. The package's final verdict is exactly this kind of bounded correction. Why this earns marks: it replaces slogan with process and respects both decline and creation.

Remedial 06 - Why Kannauj rose

Which correction best answers the oversimplified claim "Kannauj rose because Harsha liked it"?

- A. It rose only because of Buddhism.
- B. Its strategic doab position, fortifiability and Maukhari inheritance mattered within a changed political order.
- C. It was chosen randomly.
- D. It had no relation to routes.

Answer: B. This restores historical causation. Why this earns marks: it converts personality into structure, which is exactly what UPSC rewards.

Remedial 07 - Xuanzang's travel account

Which correction best addresses the claim "Xuanzang personally verified every place he described"?

- A. He never visited India.
- B. He wrote only about Sri Lanka.
- C. Parts of his account may depend on hearsay or earlier reports, so his text must be read through audience and genre.
- D. He was a Chalukya general.

Answer: C. Upinder explicitly builds this caution into the reading of the source. Why this earns marks: it keeps the source useful while marking its epistemic boundary.

Remedial 08 - Eastern India's timing

Which correction best repairs the statement "Eastern India became important only in the Pala age"?

- A. It was historically empty before 750 CE.
- B. It mattered only to Chinese pilgrims.
- C. It was significant only for ports.
- D. Gupta and post-Gupta centuries already show grants, states, Sanskrit charters, military camps and agrarian expansion across Bengal, Odisha and Assam.

Answer: D. This is one of the deepest structural lessons of Topic 22. Why this earns marks: it restores the long eastern transition rather than starting history too late.

Original solved Mains 01 - Why is Harsha better described as a north Indian hegemon than a pan-Indian emperor?

Demand and thesis (10 marks): The answer must show both real power and hard limits.

Model answer: [CLAIM] Harsha was a substantial north Indian hegemon, but not a pan-Indian emperor on the Mauryan or Ashokan scale. [EVIDENCE AND ANALYSIS] 1. His direct core included Thanesar, much of Uttar Pradesh and parts of Bihar, with probable extension into Odisha after Maukhari absorption. 2. Peripheral rulers such as those of Kamarupa and Valabhi may have acknowledged his superiority, showing wide prestige. 3. The Aihole inscription records that Pulakeshin II checked him at the Narmada, proving that the Deccan lay beyond stable control. 4. Gauda under Shashanka remained a serious eastern rival, and even victory there was not permanently final. [LIMIT] Bana magnifies the ruler and Xuanzang admires him, so territorial language must be graded. [VERDICT] Harsha therefore unified much of north India but ruled through layered influence and sharp frontiers rather than all-India imperial incorporation. **Why this earns marks:** It answers the directive directly, uses four named evidence units, shows what each proves, adds a source qualification and ends with a bounded verdict.

Original solved Mains 02 - How do land grants illuminate the spread of civilisation in eastern India between the 4th and 7th centuries?

Demand and thesis (10 marks): The answer must turn charters into process, not just list gifts.

Model answer: [CLAIM] Eastern land grants illuminate how frontier or thinly integrated regions became agrarian, literate and politically ordered state societies. [EVIDENCE AND ANALYSIS] 1. Pundravardhanabhukti plates record the purchase of fallow land with *dinaras*, then its donation for religious purposes, proving both monetised transaction and agrarian expansion. 2. Odisha charters and agraharas show the spread of Sanskrit, Brahmanical learning and new fiscal districts into fresh zones. 3. Sharma notes that scribes, merchants, landholders and even cultivators could appear in land transactions, revealing local administration and social layering. 4. The king's growing rights over waste land and revenue show that grants created new landed authority. [LIMIT] Charters privilege elite beneficiaries and do not directly narrate peasant experience in equal detail. [VERDICT] Land grants are thus key windows into eastern state formation, agrarian growth and social differentiation. **Why this earns marks:** It converts records into historical mechanism and keeps an explicit elite-source caution.

Original solved Mains 03 - Assess the importance of Kannauj in the post-Gupta political order.

Demand and thesis (15 marks): The answer must move beyond city-description to political geography.

Model answer: [CLAIM] Kannauj became important because it embodied the changed political geography of the post-Gupta age: inheritance politics, strategic control of the doab and the prestige of a new sovereignty centre converged there. [EVIDENCE AND ANALYSIS] 1. The Maukhari connection brought Kannauj into the Pushyabhuti sphere through Rajyashri's marriage to Grahavarman. 2. Sharma argues that while Pataliputra had belonged to a trade-rich earlier imperial order, Kannauj suited a more military-camp-centred age. 3. Its middle-doab location allowed movement into eastern and western Ganga plains by land and water, making it a superior command node. 4. Harsha's move from Thanesar to Kannauj transformed the city into the main emblem of north Indian sovereignty. 5. After Harsha's death, the later struggle for Kannauj among major lineages proves that its symbolic and strategic value outlived the king himself. [LIMIT] Its rise should not be used to claim uniform urban collapse elsewhere. [VERDICT] Kannauj mattered because it crystallised the transition from older imperial geography to an early medieval politics of strategic regional capitals. **Why this earns marks:** It links alliance, geography, strategy and later significance into one argument instead of writing a flat city note.

Original solved Mains 04 - Evaluate Xuanzang as a source for Harsha's India.

Demand and thesis (15 marks): The answer must balance value and bias.

Model answer: [CLAIM] Xuanzang is one of the most valuable sources for Harsha's India, but only when read as a Buddhist pilgrim-intellectual writing later in China for a specific audience. [EVIDENCE AND ANALYSIS] 1. He offers vivid material on Kannauj, Harsha's court, the Prayaga assembly and the prestige of Nalanda, giving historians

otherwise unavailable descriptive detail. 2. His route record illuminates monasteries, pilgrimage networks and the intellectual movement of texts between India and China. 3. He preserves important fiscal and administrative clues, such as light taxation and the one-sixth grain share, though these must be checked against inscriptions. 4. Upinder notes that some of his descriptions may rest on hearsay or earlier reports, and that he could idealise India for Tang monastic-imperial purposes. 5. His presentation of Harsha as a model Buddhist king therefore requires comparison with Bana, inscriptions and Aihole. [LIMIT] Xuanzang's silence is as important as his narrative; he does not provide an evenly distributed social survey. [VERDICT] Xuanzang is indispensable, but not self-sufficient: his true value emerges when triangulated with literary and epigraphic counter-evidence. **Why this earns marks:** It answers value and limitation together, uses named examples and ends with a method-aware verdict.

Original solved Mains 05 - Discuss the transition from imperial Gupta rule to regional early medieval formations with special reference to Harsha, Gauda and Kamarupa.

Demand and thesis (20 marks): The answer must connect political fragmentation with regional state formation.

Model answer: [CLAIM] The transition from imperial Gupta concentration to the early medieval order was not a simple collapse; it was a redistribution of power into regional state formations, with Harsha, Gauda and Kamarupa standing at different points in that process. [EVIDENCE AND ANALYSIS] 1. After the imperial Guptas, Upinder identifies Later Guptas, Maukharis, Pushyabhutis and Maitrakas as coexisting northern lines, showing fragmentation rather than a single successor empire. 2. Harsha built a real north Indian core from Thanesar and Kannauj, proving that reunification remained possible at a regional scale. 3. Shashanka's Gauda shows Bengal emerging as an autonomous eastern power, not merely a dependent frontier of the Ganga core. 4. Kamarupa under Bhaskaravarman illustrates simultaneous state consolidation in the Brahmaputra valley through grants, Sanskrit kingship and wider political intervention. 5. Bengal and Odisha land charters reveal military camps, fiscal districts and agrarian expansion, proving that political fragmentation could coexist with stronger local state structures. 6. The Narmada check by Pulakeshin II demonstrates the southern limit of north Indian hegemonic expansion. 7. Harsha's death and the later Kannauj struggle show that no all-India successor emerged, while the east continued toward later Pala consolidation. [LIMIT] Source density is uneven and much depends on literary or routed evidence. [VERDICT] The post-Gupta world was therefore a field of regional reorganisation in which Harsha, Gauda and Kamarupa each exemplified a different scale of early medieval state formation. **Why this earns marks:** It integrates seven evidence units into one causal argument, balances contraction and creation, and does not mistake regionalisation for mere anarchy.

Original solved Mains 06 - Critically examine whether the post-Gupta age was mainly an age of decline or of regional reorganisation.

Demand and thesis (20 marks): The answer must show historiographical balance, not slogan warfare.

Model answer: [CLAIM] The post-Gupta age contained real decline in some earlier imperial and urban forms, but its dominant long-term historical significance lies in regional reorganisation through land grants, new states, agrarian expansion and reworked sovereignty. [EVIDENCE AND ANALYSIS] 1. Sharma's contrast between falling Pataliputra and rising Kannauj captures a structural shift from old commercial-imperial centrality to a more military-strategic political geography. 2. The growth of land-based remuneration and stronger intermediaries under Harsha points toward decentralising tendencies. 3. Yet Bengal, Odisha and Assam simultaneously show expanding inscriptions, fiscal districts, grants, military camps and new state systems, proving that the period was politically generative. 4. Shashanka's Gauda and Bhaskaravarman's Kamarupa show that the east was not declining into silence; it was entering mature regional visibility. 5. Nalanda's fame and trans-Asian intellectual traffic reveal concentrated institutional vitality rather than civilisational exhaustion. 6. The Aihole check on Harsha proves not simple weakness, but the multiplication of strong regional powers. 7. Later struggles for Kannauj and eventual Pala consolidation show that the age generated enduring regional-centred political structures. [LIMIT] The answer should not deny local urban contraction, monetisation change or growing rural hierarchy where evidence supports them. [VERDICT] The most defensible judgement is that decline in certain older forms and regional reorganisation in new forms occurred together, but the longer historical arc favours the language of early medieval reorganisation over that of a dark age. **Why this earns marks:** It directly stages the historiographical issue, uses seven named evidence units, grants real weight to decline arguments and still reaches a reasoned synthesis.